made to prove their belonging."

The protest capped weeks of escalating tension over the SIR. The TMC alleges the Election Commission (EC) is using the exercise to erase genuine voters, especially minorities, migrants and the rural poor, ahead of the 2026 assembly election. TMC national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee expanded SIR as "Silent Invisible Rigging", claiming it has created panic and despair across Bengal.

Takeaways

- **TMC stages massive march through Kolkata to highlight six deaths**
- **In her emotive pitch, Mamata describes it as a fight for Bengal's soul**
- **BJP complains to EC that state govt is freely issuing identity papers**

That sense of doom has found human form: six reported deaths, which the TMC claims are linked to the fear of being struck off the rolls. Among them: Pradeep Kar of Agarpara, 57, who left behind a note blaming "NRC" and "voter verification"; Hasina Begum of Dankuni, 60, who died of a heart attack after her name allegedly vanished from an old list; and migrant worker Bimal Santra from Burdwan, who died in Tamil Nadu, allegedly haunted by the SIR. Looking over the crowd that had assembled within 48 hours of the rally being called, Abhishek said: "In the seven days since SIR was announced, we have lost several of our citizens. Their families are here on this stage today." He reminded the crowd of the 13 young people who died during Mamata's 1993 Youth Congress rally for voting rights—the episode that cemented her political rise. "Even if we have to sacrifice our lives again, we will bow only to the ten crore people of Bengal, not to Delhi," he thundered.

The TMC's strategy extends far beyond. Abhishek has directed party workers to keep vigil in every mohalla, ward and panchayat during the SIR period—with help desks for assistance in filling out forms, accompanying Booth Level Officers (BLOs) during verification visits et al. It has filed multiple complaints alleging that Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leaders were threatening BLOs, forcing the EC to issue warnings.

THE COMIC COUNTER

The BJP calls it melodrama. State chief Samik Bhattacharya says the TMC is "manufacturing fear to cover up its insecurities". The party has also lodged a complaint with the EC alleging birth and caste certificates are being issued freely, urging a strict mandate on who can issue these papers so as to preclude any illegality. Beyond that, derision, designed to instil disbelief, is a key part of its SOP.

Leader of the Opposition Suvendu Adhikari dismissed the reported suicides as "fake claims". "Pradeep Kar did not even have four fingers on his right arm. How could he write a suicide note?" he mocked. BJP workers circulated a meme of a tiger lying dead with a note beside it blaming "NRC" for its death—a darkly comic counter. Yet it may have to contend with one fact: the deaths have already altered the political atmosphere. ■

▶ KERALA

A MILESTONE AND SOME DUST ON IT

Kerala claims it has eradicated extreme poverty, but Pinarayi's welfare attire isn't all stain-free

By **Jeemon Jacob**

TOTAL LITERACY BACK IN 1991, FAMOUSLY. After 34 years, on its foundation day of November 1, Kerala marked the next pioneer's milestone: total eradication of extreme poverty. At least, that claim has been formally made by chief minister Pinarayi Vijayan, who called it a "historic moment" that embellished Kerala's repute as a "caring state". With his Left-led government due to test the strength of its two-term incumbency in assembly polls next year, such a claim was not about to go without furious contestation. As pro-regime voices battle a sceptical chorus—not limited to the Opposition—the surrounding context also offered a more complex picture.

It was in 2021 that the state set freedom from extreme poverty as an absolute goal.

JOJI VARGHESE



MAKESHIFT LIFE A tribal family in Noolpuzha village, Wayanad, Oct. 30